What Shall I Tell My Children About Atlanta?

By Ntozake Shange, Langston Hughes and Margaret Burroughs

INTRODUCTION

What do you think of when I say Atlanta, Georgia? Gone with the Wind . . . peaches . . . beautiful plantation mansions? Atlanta has a rich history – but it wasn't always peaches and plantations.

Today, I want to take you back to Atlanta in the early 1980's. Between 1979 and 1981, at least 28 poor, black children vanished from Atlanta's streets, their bodies turning up days or weeks later — strangled, asphyxiated, shot, bludgeoned, stabbed. Most of the child murders remain unsolved. Why?

What Shall I Tell My Children About Atlanta? – A Collection by Ntozake Shange, Langston Hughes and Margaret Burroughs

About Atlanta by Ntozake Shange

(Pgs 1076-1078) Cuz he's black & poor
he's disappeared
the name waz lost the games werent played
nobody tucks him in at night/ wipes traces

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of cornbread & syrup from his fingers
the corners of his mouth
cuz he's black & poor / he's not
just gone
disappeared one day
& his blood soaks up what's awready red
in atlanta

no ropes this time no tar & feathers
werent no parades of sheets fires & crosses
nothing/ no signs

empty bunkbeds
mothers who forget & cook too much on Sundays
just gone / disappeared
cuz he's black & poor he's gone
took a bus / never heard from again
but somebody heard a child screaming
& went right on ahead
children disappearing / somewhere in the woods /
decaying
just gone / disappeared / in atlanta

mothers are always at the window watching
caint nobody disappear right in fronta yr eyes
but who knows what we cd do
when we're black & poor
we aint here no way / how cd we disappear?
who wd hear us screaming?

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say it was a man with a badge & some candy
say it was a man with a badge & some money
say it was a maniac
cd be more n sticks n stones
gotta be more than stars n stripes
children caint play war when they in one.
caint make believe they dyin/when they are
caint imagine what they'll be / cuz they wont
just gone / disappeared

oh mary dont you weep & dont you moan
oh mary dont you weep & dont you moan
HOLLAR i say HOLLAR
cuz we black & poor & we just disappear

we cant find em jesus cant find em
til they seepin in soil
father reekin in soil
they bones bout disappeared
they lives aint never been
bleeding where the earth's awready red
dyin cuz they took a bus
& mama caint see that far out her window
the front porch dont go from here to eternity
& they gone
just disappeared

but somebody heard them screaming
somebody crushed them children's bones

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somebody's walkin who shd be crawling
for killing who aint never been
cuz we black & poor / we just be gone

no matter how sweet/ no matter how quiet
just gone
be right back ma
going to the store mother dear
see ya later nana

& the soil runs red with our dead in atlanta
cuz somebody went right on ahead
crushing them lil bones / strangling them frail wails
cuz we black & poor
our blook soaks up dirt
while we disappearing

mamas keep looking out the door
saying "i wonder where is my child / i wonder
where is my child"
she don't turn the bed back cuz she knows
we black & poor
& we just disappear / be gone

oh mary dont you weep & dont you moan
oh mary dont you weep & dont you moan
i wonder where is my child
i wonder where is my child

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nothing / no signs
in atlanta

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ntozake Shange
Book: The Aunt Lute Anthology of U. S. Women Writers, Vol. 2: The 20th Century (eds Lisa M. Hogeland and Shay Brown) Pgs 1076-1078
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier

TRANSITION

For generations, Black Americans have been operating under an inherited suspicion that no one will care if the worst happens to them. If 28 white children were murdered in Atlanta, would the police response have been the same?

*Would the response **today** be different? Do Black lives matter? – Yes. Do Poor lives matter? - Yes. The hard question is: To what degree?*

Kids Who Die by Langston Hughes

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Kids Who Die by Langston Hughes

(Pg 138) This is for the kids who die,

Black and white,

For kids will die certainly.

The old and rich will live on awhile,

As always,

Eating blood and gold,

Letting kids die.

Kids will die in the swamps of Mississippi

Organizing sharecroppers.

Kids will die in the streets of Chicago

Organizing workers.

Kids will die in the orange groves of California

Telling others to get together.

Whites and Filipinos,

Negroes and Mexicans,

All kinds of kids will die

Who don't believe in lies, and bribes, and contentment

And a lousy peace.

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Of course, the wise and the learned
Who pen editorials in the papers,
And the gentlemen with Dr. in front of their names.
White and black,
Who make surveys and write books
Will live on weaving words to smother the kids who die,
And the sleazy courts,
And the bribe-reaching police,
And the blood-loving generals,
And the money-loving preachers
Will all raise their hands against the kids who die,
Beating them with laws and clubs and bayonets and bullets
To frighten the people—
For the kids who die are like iron in the blood of the
people—
And the old and rich don't want the people
To taste the iron of the kids who die,
Don't want the people to get wise to their own power,
To believe an Angelo Herndon, or even get together

Listen, kids who die—
Maybe, now, there will be no monument for you

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Except in our hearts
Maybe your bodies'll be lost in a swamp.
Or a prison grave, or the potter's field,
Or the rivers where you're drowned like Leibknecht
But the day will come—
You are sure yourselves that it is coming—
When the marching feet of the masses
Will raise for you a living monument of love,
And joy, and laughter,
And black hands and white hands clasped as one,
And a song that reaches the sky—

The song of the life triumphant
Through the kids who die.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Langston Hughes
Book: The Collected Works of Langston Hughes, Volume 1 (1921-1940), Pg 138+
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Date (Month/Year): 2001

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What Shall I Tell My Children Who Are Black by Margaret Burroughs (Excerpt)

What shall I tell my children who are black
Of what it means to be a captive in this dark skin
What shall I tell my dear one,
Of how beautiful they are when everywhere they turn
They are faced with abhorrence of everything that is black.
Villains are black with black hearts.
A black cow gives no milk. A black hen lays no eggs.
Bad news comes bordered in black, black is evil
And evil is black and devils' food is black. . .

What shall I tell my dear ones raised in a white world
A place where white has been made to represent
All that is good and pure and fine and decent.
Where clouds are white, and dolls, and heaven
Surely is a white, white place with angels
Robed in white, and cotton candy and ice cream
and milk and ruffled Sunday dresses
And dream houses and long sleek cadillacs
And angel's food is white. . . all, all. . . white.

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What can I say therefore, when my child
Comes home in tears because a playmate
Has called him black, big lipped, flatnosed
and nappy headed? What will he think
When I dry his tears and whisper, "Yes, that's true.
But no less beautiful and dear."
How shall I lift up his head, get him to square
His shoulders, look his adversaries in the eye,
Confident of the knowledge of his worth,
Serene under his sable skin and proud of his own beauty?

What can I do to give him strength
That he may come through life's adversities
As a whole human being unwarped and human in a world
Of biased laws and inhuman practices, that he might
Survive. And survive he must! For who knows?
Perhaps this black child here bears the genius
To discover the cure for. . . Cancer
Or to chart the course for exploration of the universe.
So, he must survive for the good of all humanity.
He must and will survive.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Margaret Burroughs
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https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/146263/what-shall-i-tell-my-children-who-are-black-reflections-of-an-african-american-mother
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SOURCE INFORMATION

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